

	Course Instructors: DR. MARK CHETAMBE, DR. STEPHEN MUTIE Email: mutali.mark@ku.ac.ke ; mutie.stephen@ku.ac.ke Semester 1, 2026/2027 (B.A, B.Ed Degree Programme)
Department	Department of Literature, Linguistics and Foreign Languages
UNIT CODE AND TITLE	ALT 101/111: INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY GENRES

1. COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course introduces students to the major forms of literature: poetry, prose, oral literature and drama. The course is designed to enable students to understand the nature and function of literary genres and the respective subgenres in terms of their unique characteristics. The course intends to give students an overview of literature, its mode of presentation, and its thematic concerns. This will make it easy for students to identify, describe, and discuss various genres of literature. This course will also explore the similarities and differences between the different genres of literature.

2. OBJECTIVES

By the end of the course, learners should be able to:

- Identify and explain the various genres of literature
- Discuss the aspects of form and content that inform different genres
- Discuss the functions of literary genres

3. COURSE CONTENT- Divided into weekly Delivery

Week 1: Course Introduction and Orientation

- Rationale for generic study of literature
- Course expectations, objectives, and assessment outline
- Syllabus overview

Week 2: Nature and Function of Literature

- What is literature? Form, content, and thematic concerns
- Purpose and functions of literary genres across cultures
- Introductory theoretical concepts

Week 3: Oral Literature (Orature): Nature and Characteristics

- Unique features of oral art: performance, audience, dynamics
- Subgenres: narratives (myths, legends, folktales), songs, short forms

Week 4: Oral Literature in Modern Society

- Transition from oral to written forms
- Function and relevance of orature in contemporary culture
- Selected oral performance recordings
- Elements of prose: plot, characterization, setting, point of view

Week 5: Prose Fiction and Narrative Analysis

- Short story vs. novel structures

- In-depth analysis of prose style, social commentary, and realism
- *Uncle Ben's Choice* by Chinua Achebe OR *The Story of an Hour* by Kate Chopin
- *The River Between* by Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o

Week 6: CAT 1- Sit-in (1hour)

Week 7: Poetry: Nature and Structural Characteristics

- Key considerations: imagery, diction, rhythm, meter, tone, speaker
- Classification: lyric, narrative, dramatic, epic, elegy, sonnet
- Class Poetry Handout

Week 8: Poetry: Analysis and Interpretation

- Practical criticism: applying close reading techniques
- Form vs. content in African poetic traditions
- *A Selection of African Poetry* – Handout

Week 9: Drama: Nature and Conventions of Dramatic Art

- Drama as text vs. performance
- Key elements: dialogue, stage directions, action, conflict, spectacle
- Drama intro excerpts

Week 10: Drama: Genres, Subgenres and Analysis

- Tragedy, comedy, tragi-comedy, satire, and farce
- Comparative study: Form, content, and cultural themes in drama
- *Aminata* by Francis Imbuga OR *The Lion and the Jewel* by Wole Soyinka

Week 11: Course Revision and Synthesis

- Comparative review of all 4 genres (Oral Lit, Prose, Poetry, Drama)
- Group discussions and past paper practice
- Review of all course materials

Week 12: Consultations and Final Exam Preparation

- Submission of Group Assignments
- Student consultation sessions
- Final exam guidance and wrap-up
- Individual / group consultations

4. REQUIREMENTS

The course will be conducted through lectures, tutorials, online activities and collaborative class discussions. The students are required to closely read the prescribed course texts and secondary texts. This will facilitate their ability to identify the characteristics of the specific genres that are the focus of the course.

5. ASSESSMENT

Course assessment will be conducted as follows:

Two Continuous Assessment Tests (CATs): 40%

Final end of semester examination: 60 %

PRIMARY TEXTS

1. *The River Between* by Ngugi Wa Thiong'o
2. *Uncle Ben's Choice* - Chinua Achebe
3. *The Story of an Hour* by Kate Chopin

4. *Aminata* by Francis Imbuga
5. *The Lion and the Jewel* - Wole Soyinka
6. Collection of poems (a handout containing a collection of poems will be given in class)

SECONDARY READING LIST

1. Abrams, M.H., & Harpham, G.G. – *A Glossary of Literary Terms*, 1957; 2014
2. Miruka, Okumba – *Understanding Oral Literature*, 1994
3. Finnegan, Ruth – *Oral Literature in Africa*, 1970
4. Lennard, John – *The Poetry Handbook: A Guide to Reading Poetry for Pleasure and Practical Criticism*, 1996; 2005
5. K.E. Senanu & T. Vincent (Eds.) – *A Selection of African Poetry*: 1976 (revised edition 1988)
6. Styan, J.L. *The Elements of Drama*, 1960
7. Weales, G. *A Play and its Parts*, 1964
8. Burts, B.B. *Types of Drama, Plays and Essays*, 1990
9. Gardner, H.C. *Norms for the Novel*, 1993

Any other text dealing with the nature, form, and function of literature.